



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 1.1 FINDING OCTAVES ON THE FRETBOARD

INTRODUCTION

Knowing where the notes exist on your fretboard, I believe is a must. Yet so few guitarists that I have met over the years take the time to familiarise themselves with them and their location on the neck.

For the most part they just fly by the seat of their pants, and at best is a guesstimate of the notes they should be playing (I know, I used to do the same).

And if you are starting out as a student of the guitar and you don't have a handle of where to find an F note everywhere on your guitar, then read this and take the time to study and process the information given here today.

Oh, and by the way if your current teacher doesn't know where all his or her notes are on the fretboard, get a new teacher!

Please set aside a little time each day (as little as 10 mins) to study this document on finding the octave notes on the fretboard as it is in the least a fantastic cross-referencing tool that you can use to help you memorise your fretboard.

Fig 1. is a diagram of every single note on the fretboard. This diagram is most likely going to be a little daunting & confusing at first glance, but please read on so you get a better understanding of the guitar fretboard so you can use it freely, making your guitar playing truly come alive!

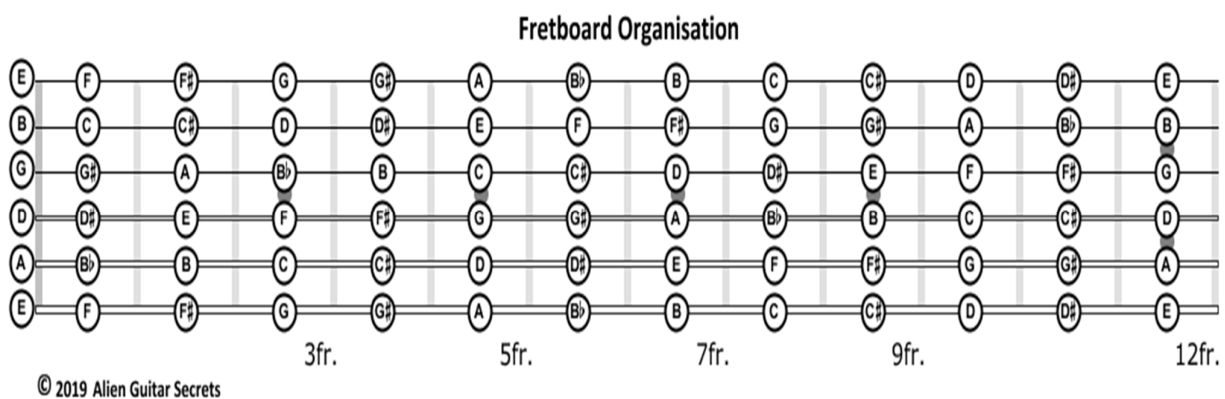


Figure 1 Notes on Fretboard

WHY DO I NEED TO KNOW WHERE ALL OF THE NOTES ARE?

Being a teacher of students, some of who have never played the guitar before, as well as of students that have played for many years, I find that it is a most vital exercise to be able to organise your fretboard.

But without a structured way of breaking down the fretboard into individual notes and octaves, finding a pattern that unlocks the fretboard can be an incredibly difficult task, as it was at first for me.

This, in fact, led to such frustration, it was discouraging, to say the least that at times I wanted to throw the guitar out the window. I thought it was going to remain a mystery for ever.

Then one day I thought about this for a long time. Through my sheer frustration of trying to learn new chords I realised that I didn't know how to identify where specific notes lived on the fretboard. It was at this point I understood how it important that was to my success upon the instrument. That if I could manage this, and finally make sense of the fretboard for good, I could then begin adding far more depth and unleash the creativity I had shackled inside of me.

The importance of understanding your playground can never be over-stated.

It allows you a large part of the freedom your guitar playing craves, as it quite simply gives options. Options for notes, options for chords and options for textures & melodies. How many of you out there only play the same locations on the neck, day in day out?

Without ever truly understanding the tool of your trade, is only ever going to make it that much more difficult to feel confident as a musician, construct melodies, finding chord inversions, and it will most certainly hinder your improvisational skills.

So, over the years, I have devised a system of teaching my students the natural directional flow of the fretboard. I insist on them spending time each day to impress this fretboard flow into their minds so that when they play, they're not guessing as to which notes live where.

Then they truly are expressing themselves freely, because the thinking of note locations has become a thing of the past, and so they move into a present moment of knowing where their expression comes from, thus making music they are creating the most important event occurring in that moment.

AIM

Our aim is to make the notes that you want to use from a particular scale or chord to light up like 'Christmas Tree Fairy Lights', giving us multiple options in any one area of the neck or the entire fretboard just like a 'Yellow Brick Road' kind of pathway.

METHOD

The method I use to teach this is quite simple. First you must know the interval separation between the frets, this is a semi tone. It follows the same principle as the chromatic scale. Therefore, each fret equals a semi tone up or down from the previous note, as in Fig 2

Every fret is the same
distance of a semi tone

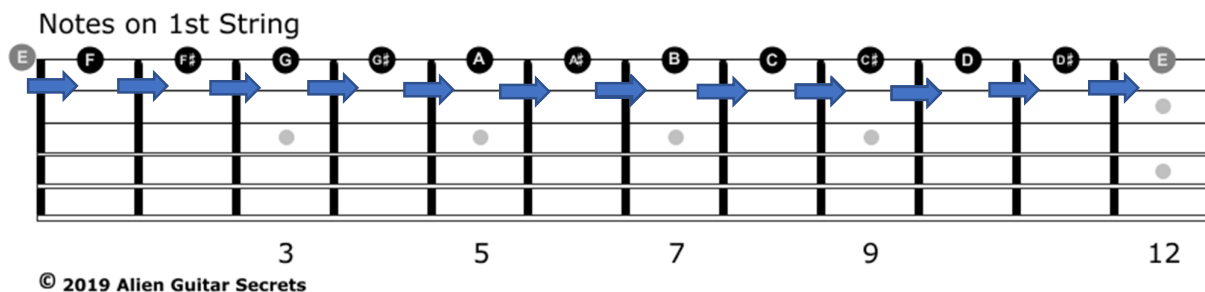


Figure 2 - Distance Between Frets

LEARNING THE NOTES

Learning each note on your guitar is easier than you might think. It's easy because I figured out that there are 5 formulas that once memorized, make understanding your fret board and where the notes live easier than ever before. However, just like any other learning experience, it requires a discipline from the student. A discipline to apply the knowledge learnt here, and every time you pick up the guitar, is a must for success. This is the only way it's ever going to work for you.

The standard tuning guitar for the guitar is in parallel fourths except for the 2nd string which is tuned to the major third of the 3rd string (fig 3). Now, stay with me because it's very important that you understand what this means.

Figure 3 below, shows us exactly how to tune the guitar by relative means. You

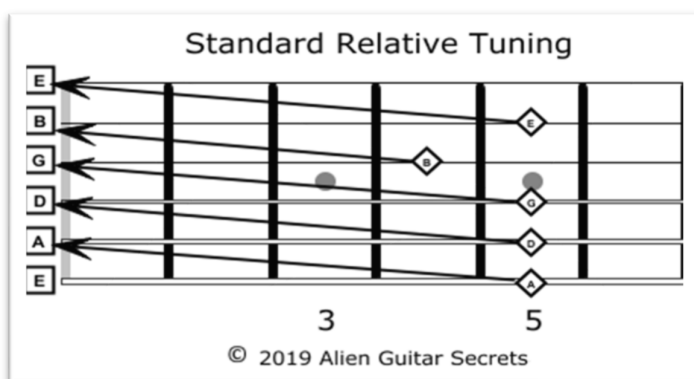


Figure 3 Relative Tuning on the Guitar

can also see the relationship of the open strings to the fretted notes on the correlating strings.

Fretting the 5th fret on the 6th string gives us the note A. This the same as the open 5th string which is also A.

Fretting the 5th fret of the 5th string gives us the note D.

Striking the open 4th string is also the note D. Noticing this

I began to look at the guitar fretboard as correlating octaves across multiple strings. This then became the basis of my five formulas in finding not only the

Octaves on the guitar, but in time it became the perfect foundation for being able to always see every note without the guess work. I had made a massive breakthrough.

FIVE STEP FORMULA TO MASTERING THE FRETBOARD

In my quest to achieve fretboard mastery, I stumbled onto a pattern of formulas that I can use to find any note on the fretboard in quick time.

I knew that by memorising these five formulas, I would release myself from all that overthinking I was doing in trying to figure where a melody lived.

When you don't know your fretboard, you believe that a songs melody and chords can only live in one place. That there are no more alternatives other than the first three frets of the guitar.

I ask you then, why the extra frets then?

Now, that maybe true for instruments like the piano, or trumpet, but for instruments like the guitar, not so! In fact, the same frequency note can exist in more than one location on different strings. Now this is a game changer!

FIRST FORMULA

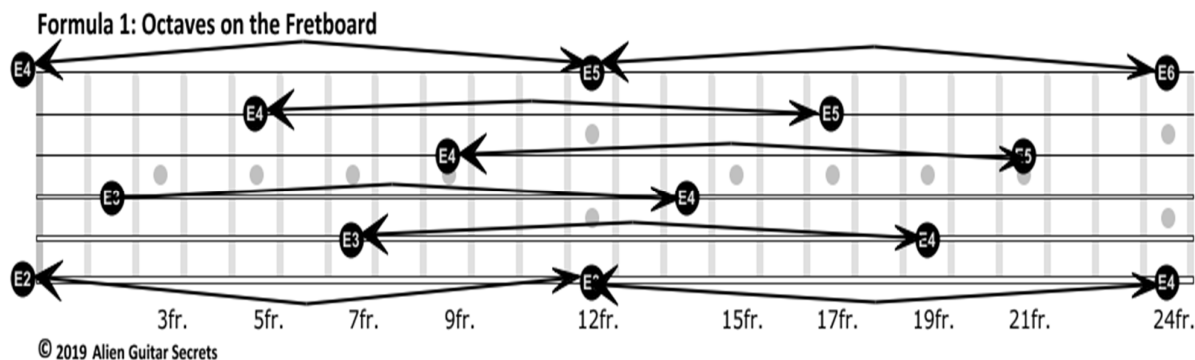


Figure 4 - First Formula: Octaves on same string

The 1st formula (fig 4) only really has 1 step to follow across all strings and shows the location of every E note on the same string. This becomes our starting point.

If you find yourself on the sixth string **E (2)** note, the next octave **E (3)** is located exactly twelve frets up the neck on 12th fret. This occurs because of the even interval spacing of the Chromatic Scale.

Now, if you were to apply this formula to any other **E** note on the fretboard, the formula still applies if you move twelve frets above or below on the same string. You can see how this formula applies in the diagram (fig 4).

FORMULAS 2 & 3

The 2nd and 3rd formulas (fig 5 & 6) show how we can begin to find our octaves on a different string other than the string that we are on.

SECOND FORMULA

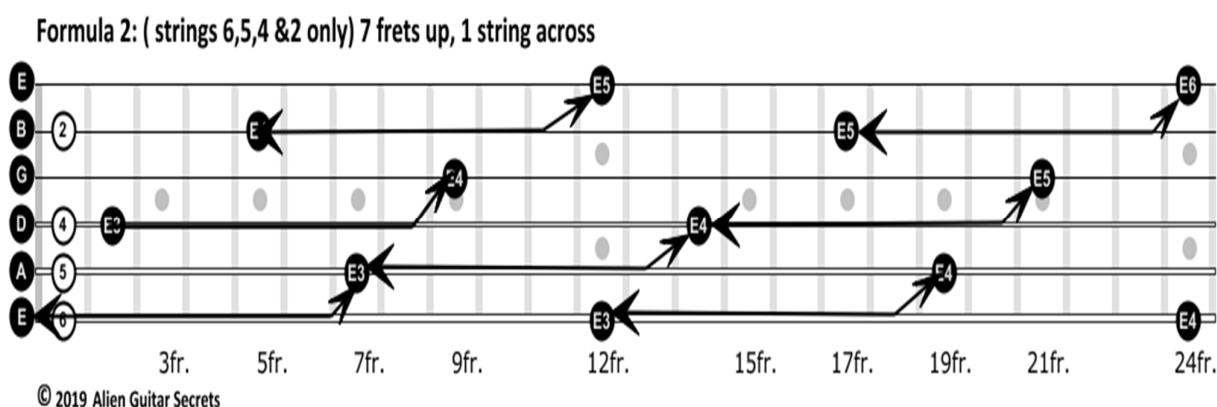


Figure 5- Second Formula

The second formula applies if you move one string across from the string you are currently on. Let's go back to the 1st fret of the sixth string **E (2)** note and move 7 frets which is the 7th fret 5th string that will be the octave of that **E (3)**. So, this formula of 7 frets and one string relates to the 6th, 5th, 4th and 2nd strings. It does not relate to 3rd or 1st strings.

Now if we go up 7 frets and one string, we would be on the 14th fret of the fourth string and we would call that another **E (4)**. We run out of fret real estate to go 12 frets up from 15 on the same string so if we go back 12 on the same string, we wind up on the 2nd fret and that is another **E (3)**, the previous octave.

Now we have our 6th, 5th and 4th string octaves if we go up 7 frets from the 2nd fret **E (3)**, we arrive at the 9th fret 3rd string **E (4)**, which incidentally is the same frequency as our 14th fret 4th string **E (4)**. Try it out.

THIRD FORMULA

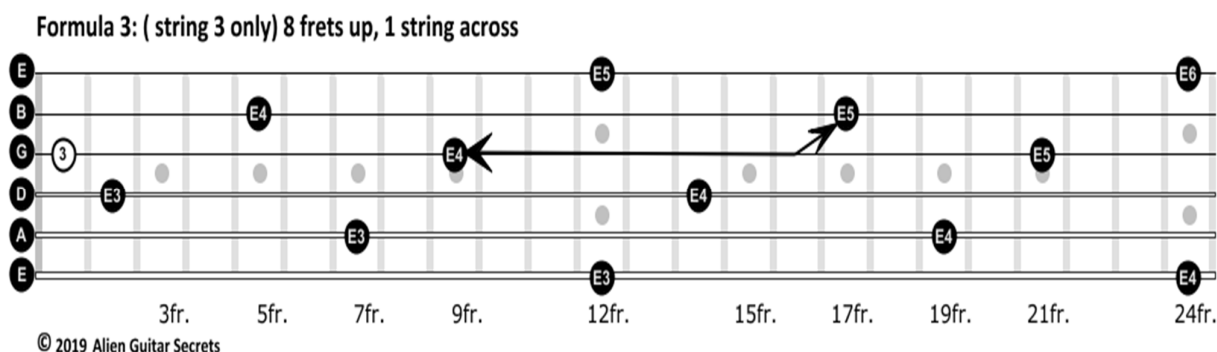


Figure 6- Third Formula

Now, this is where we must pay special attention. There is an anomaly that comes into play here. As we are on the 3rd string, remember that this 3rd string is tuned to a major third not a fourth, so, in this case, every note on the second string has its location shifted up by one fret.

Now, to find this octave we need to use a third formula (fig 6). Starting at the 3rd string at the 9th fret **E (4)**, in order to find an octave one string across from the third string, you move up eight frets and one string to the 17th fret of the 2nd string which gives us the **E (5)**.

If we don't have enough fretboard real estate to continue ascending, we can go back 12 frets to the 5th fret on the 2nd string to find our **E (4)**. Now we're back in line with second formula, where we can go up seven frets and one string to find **E (5)** on the first string. Incidentally, we can also come back 12 frets on that first string and get a previous **E (4)**.

FORMULAS 4 & 5

The fourth and fifth formulas, are not dissimilar to the second and third formulas. However, our fourth and fifth formulas involve moving across two strings from our current location. Hence, putting the octave of the root note that you want under your hand so you can see where it is in a chord formation.

THE FOURTH FORMULA

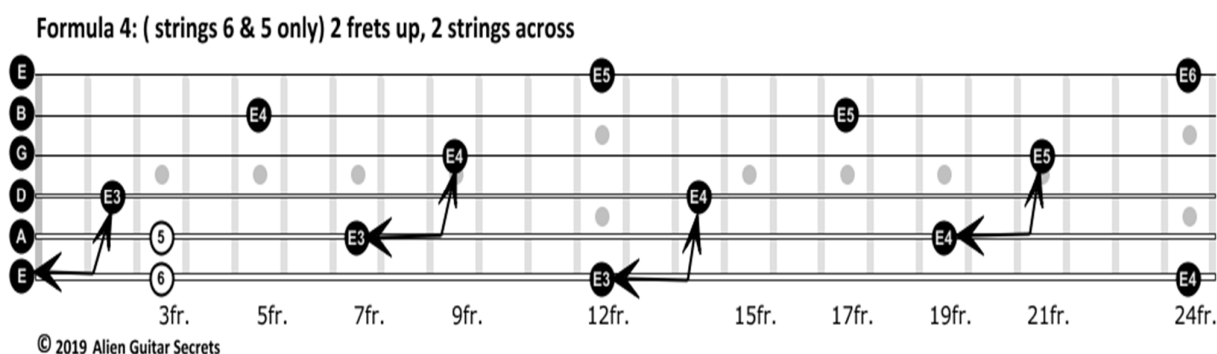


Figure 7- Fourth Formula

The fourth formula (fig 7) relates to the 6th and 5th strings and its formula is two frets up and two strings across. So, if you want to find the octave of the **E (2)** on the open 6th string move up two frets and then across two strings to the 2nd fret of the 4th string **E (3)**. Similarly, if you're on the 7th fret of the 5th string **E (3)**, and you go up two frets and two strings will end up on **E (4)**, at the 9th fret of the 3rd string.

FIFTH FORMULA

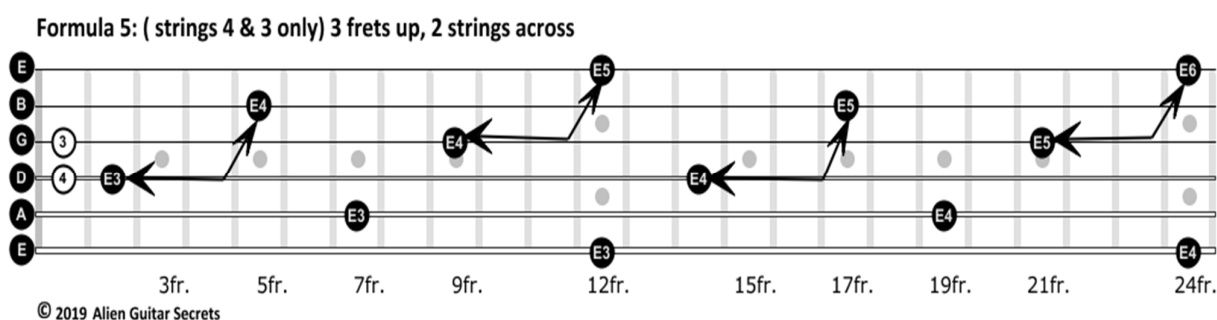


Figure 8- Fifth Formula

To cross the 3rd string, we need to use one final, and fifth formula (fig 8). Using the fifth formula, the **E (3)** is on the 2nd fret on the 4th string. In this case, you would move up three frets, because you again must account for the 3rd string crossing over to the 2nd string. The 2nd string is tuned to a major third of the 3rd string. Using this same formula on the **E (4)** note on 9th fret of the 3rd string, we would wind up on 12th fret on the 1st string **E (5)**, and that's it.

SUMMARY

So, there you have it. You only must learn a handful of formulas, five to be exact, to find any octave of the same note across the entire fretboard.

I always teach my students how to find the octaves as five formulas rather than three formulas with a part A and B. This is because it breaks down the formulas in pairs of strings making it easier to understand.

I have summarised the formulas into one concise diagram below in figure 9.

- **First formula** relates to the same note being located 12 frets up (an octave above) or 12 frets down (an octave below), on the same string
- **Second formula** relates to the 6th, 5th, 4th, and 2nd strings, go up seven frets and up and across one string.
- **Third formula** relates to 3rd string we go eight frets and one string
- **Fourth formula** relates to 6th and 5th strings; you go two frets and two strings.
- **Fifth formula** relates to 4th and 3rd string we go three frets and two strings.

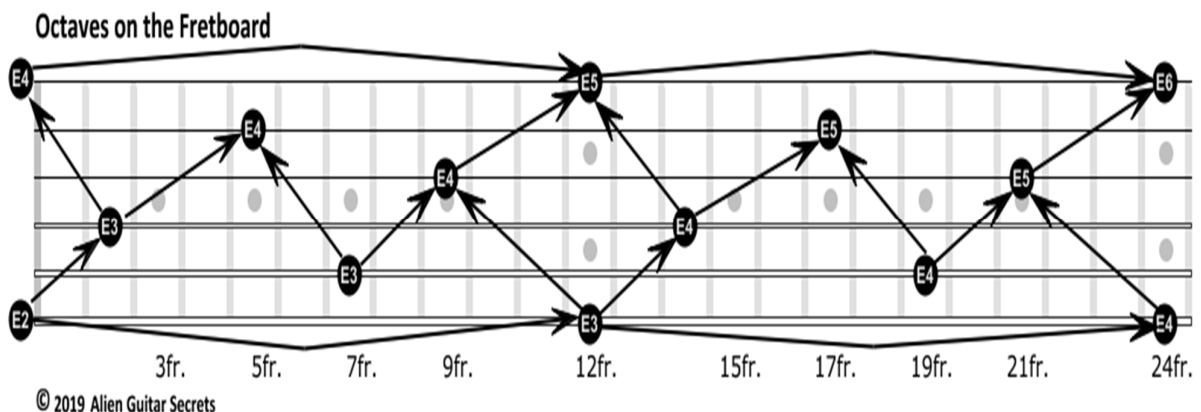


Figure 9- summary of octaves on fretboard

PRACTICE

So, now that you hopefully have better understanding of where these notes lie on the fretboard, it's time to do some exercises. Do the following exercises at the start of every practice session until you get the idea of where the notes are.

Take it slow. Build up to the tempo markers in the exercises, and it's a must to use a metronome with these exercises, as it will give you the incentive you need as well as giving a progression indicator; the faster the tempo the easier you can recognise the notes.

Choose a different note each Try not to pick the note right next door to the note you chose yesterday because that defeats the purpose. What you want to try and do is to get more fretboard coverage by placing yourself in situations that force you to go through those exercises over and over.

INTEGRATION

Integration of the note identification principles in every part of your playing is essential to rapid growth in understanding your fretboard.

You can for instance, learn the notes by singing them out as you practice all your scales.

Not only does this help you recognise the note locations, it also helps to connect a tonality to the note name you are practicing to remember.

Do this all over the fretboard both with scales as much with the practice arpeggios of chords. There are numerous ways you can practice memorising the notes on the fretboard, and not knowing them is just adding to your pain, so get on it!

EXERCISES

E
Exercise 1

el.guit. **4/4**

1 0 2 5 7 9 12 14 17 19 21 24

F

3 1 3 6 8 10 13 15 18 20 22

G

5 3 5 8 10 12 15 17 20 22 24

A

7 2 5 7 10 12 14 17 19 22 24

B

9 2 4 7 9 12 14 16 19 21 24

C

11 1 3 5 8 10 13 15 17 20 22

Figure 10- Exercise 1 - Octaves

el.guit. **D** 13 10 15 14 22 24

E Exercise 2 15 16 5 0 12

F 17 18 6 1 13

G 19 28 8 3 15

A 21 22 10 5 17

B 23 24 12 7 19

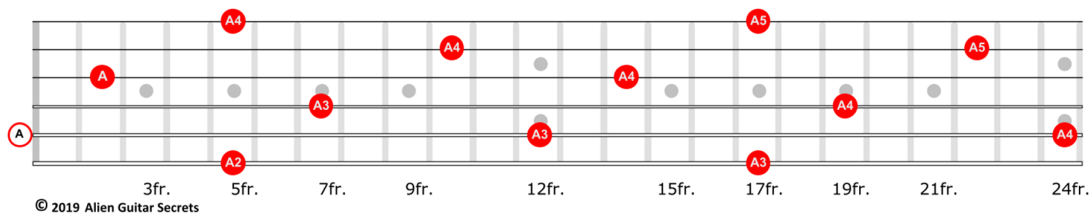
C 25 26 13 8 20

D 27 28 15 10 22

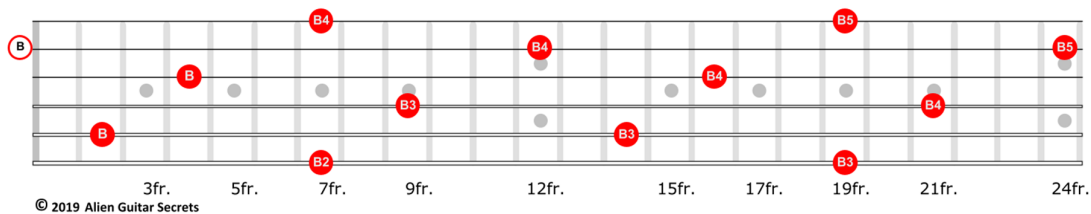
Tablature notation showing fret numbers (0-24) on a six-line staff. The sequence of notes across the octaves is: D (13), E (10), F (15), G (14), A (22), B (24), C (24), and D (24).

Figure 11- Exercise 2- Octaves

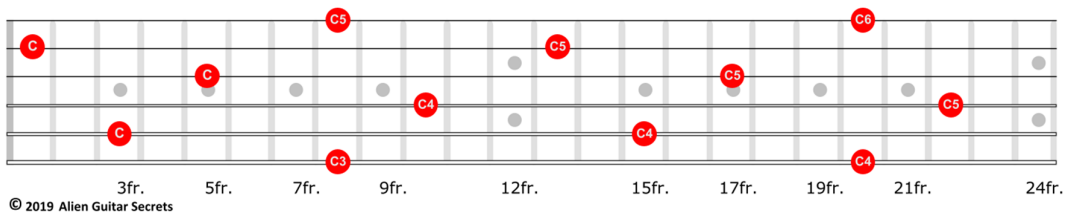
Octaves on the Fretboard - A



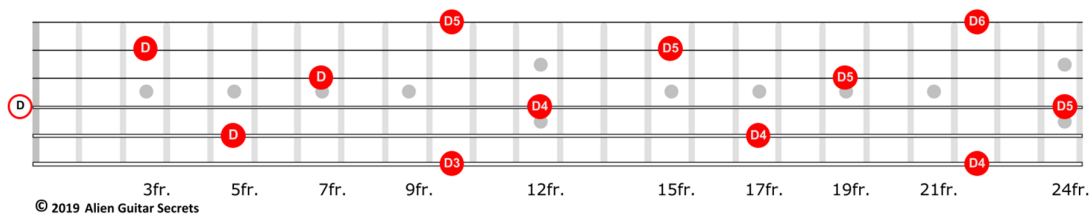
Octaves on the Fretboard - B



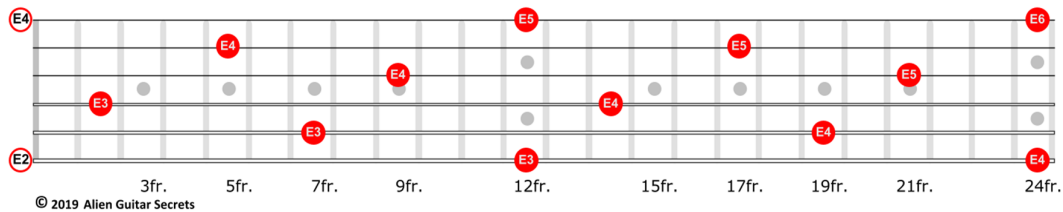
Octaves on the Fretboard - C



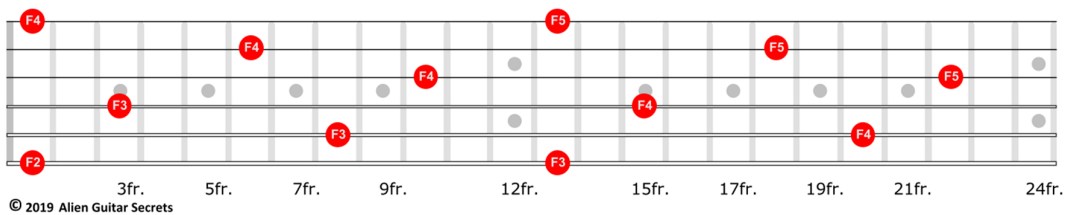
Octaves on the Fretboard - D



Octaves on the Fretboard - E



Octaves on the Fretboard - F



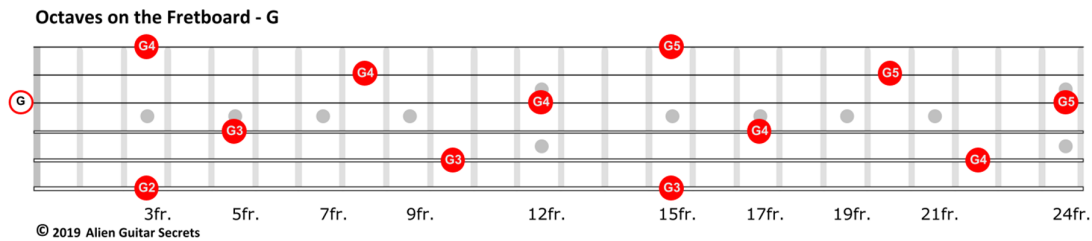


Figure 12- Fretboard Visualisation of Natural Notes In Octaves

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

So, how long does it take to know where all the notes are on the fretboard?

There is no set length of time that I could put on this exercise, except to say that it will take you a very long time if you don't do it because you will be guessing and stumbling around the neck anyways.

Are there progress indicators I can look for to show me that I am getting better? Yes! You, begin to see, not only the chosen octaves and be able to name them, but you also begin to recognise the notes next to them. You also begin seeing the natural angular ascent of the octaves across the fretboard.

How do you know you have got it? When you see every note on the fretboard cold! It's as though your peripheral vision of the fretboard expands exponentially and very dramatically as I seem to recall.

Your ability to see potential modulations for the creation of licks, of scales and chord inversions is the perfect reward and because a whole new world of understanding washes over you, inspiration is not hard to find.

If you know where the notes are on the fretboard, I promise the goal of becoming a much better guitar player is a lot closer because you have done this work.

The guitar unlike most other instruments, is home to the same frequency of note in multiple locations (fig5). The reason is as stated many times in this chapter, the strings overlap and are tuned in parallel fourths except for the 3rd string, for this we tune the 2nd string to a major 3rd of the 3rd string.

CONCLUSION

Now, I know that this is going to take time to learn and commit to memory these new formulas, and that's ok. I want you to be ok with this too.

Be patient and kind with yourself. I hope that this finally puts to bed, the question of knowing how to get started in understanding where the notes live on the guitar.

Your success will come in the commitment you make to learning it. By committing the first five minutes of your daily practice routine to the exercises, getting to know the notes on the fretboard is not a far away, never to be achieved target.

Within a few short weeks you will begin to see the fruits of your labour, and will never look at the fretboard feeling lost ever again!

Rock On \m/

Rob